Reading circle packet

Six weeks, one short reading a week, the same four questions every time. You don't need to be an expert. I'm still learning too.

Where to start

1. Ask 3 to 5 people you trust.
2. Pick a time and a place. Once a week for an hour.
3. Read one short piece each week. If someone didn't finish, they should still come.
4. Talk with the four questions on each page.
5. After a few weeks, pick one thing to do together.

The six weeks

1. Frantz Fanon, "Racism and Culture"
2. Marx and Engels, *The Communist Manifesto*, Part I
3. Walter Rodney, *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa*, chapter 1
4. Johanna Fernández, *The Young Lords*, one chapter
5. Gal Beckerman, *The Quiet Before*, the introduction
6. Thomas Sowell, *Intellectuals and Society*, one chapter

A few ground rules

- Everyone gets a turn before anyone talks twice.
- Push on ideas and stay kind to people.
- What people share about their lives stays in the room.
- Nobody has to agree, and nobody has to have read everything.

Most of these books are at the public library. More at hoto.lol/reading-circle

READING CIRCLE · WEEK 1

Frantz Fanon, "Racism and Culture"

From *Toward the African Revolution*, translated by Haakon Chevalier (Grove Press, 1967), pages 31 to 44. Fanon gave this speech in Paris in September 1956, at the First Congress of Negro Writers and Artists. He was 31 and working as a psychiatrist in Algeria during its war for independence.

1. Racism is part of a system

> *"Racism, as we have seen, is only one element of a vaster whole: that of the systematized oppression of a people." (p. 33)*

A system that takes land, labor and wealth needs a story that says the people it takes from deserve it. Racism is that story.

2. Racism changes its disguise

> *"The object of racism is no longer the individual man but a certain form of existing." (p. 33)*

Old racism attacked bodies. Newer racism goes after a way of living: food, music, faith, family, language. It can sound polite and do the same work.

3. Colonial rule freezes a culture

> *"The cultural mummification leads to a mummification of individual thinking." (p. 34)*

When a culture can't grow, the people in it get stuck too. That's the psychiatrist talking.

4. Racism is learned, so it can be unlearned

> *"The racist in a culture with racism is therefore normal." (p. 40)*

> *"Racism is therefore not a constant of the human spirit." (p. 41)*

Most racism comes from ordinary people doing what their culture taught them. People built it, so people can take it apart.

5. Holding on to a culture that was looked down on

> *"This culture, abandoned, sloughed off, rejected, despised, becomes for the inferiorized an object of passionate attachment." (p. 41)*

When your culture is mocked, you hold it tighter. Fanon sees why, and also warns it can turn into living in the past.

How he ends

> *"The two cultures can affront each other, enrich each other." (p. 44)*

Cultures can meet as equals once one isn't ruling the other.

Talk it through

1. What stood out to you?
2. Where do you see this in our lives right now?
3. What confused you, or what do you disagree with?
4. What's one small thing we could try?

Quotes checked against the 1967 English edition. Page numbers come from a scanned copy and could be off by one. More at hoto.lol/reading-circle

READING CIRCLE · WEEK 2

Marx and Engels, *The Communist Manifesto*, Part I

Part I is called "Bourgeois and Proletarians." Marx and Engels wrote the Manifesto for a small workers' group, the Communist League, and it came out in London in February 1848. Quotes use the 1888 English translation by Samuel Moore, edited by Engels. "Bourgeoisie" means the owners of businesses and factories. "Proletarians" means people who live by selling their work for a wage.

1. History as a fight between classes

> *"The history of all hitherto existing society is the history of class struggles."*

Their claim is that in every era, one group owned what mattered and another group did the work, and the tension between them moved history.

2. Money became the main tie

> *"...no other nexus between man and man than naked self-interest, than callous 'cash payment'."*

Older ties like duty, loyalty and faith got pushed aside. More of life turned into buying and selling.

3. Everything keeps changing

> *"All that is solid melts into air, all that is holy is profaned..."*

> *"The need of a constantly expanding market for its products chases the bourgeoisie over the entire surface of the globe."*

Written in 1848, this reads a lot like globalization today.

4. Work loses its meaning

> *"He becomes an appendage of the machine..."*

With machines and split-up tasks, workers repeat one small step and lose the craft and pride in the work.

5. The real win is people uniting

> *"The real fruit of their battles lies, not in the immediate result, but in the ever expanding union of the workers."*

> *"This union is helped on by the improved means of communication that are created by modern industry..."*

Factories put workers side by side, and new tools let them find each other. This is the part about organizing at scale.

A fair thing to argue about

> *"What the bourgeoisie therefore produces, above all, are its own grave-diggers."*

Some of their predictions came true and some didn't. Which ones do you think held up?

Talk it through

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4. What's one small thing we could try?

Quotes checked against the Samuel Moore translation on marxists.org, Chapter 1. More at hoto.lol/reading-circle

READING CIRCLE · WEEK 3

Walter Rodney, *How Europe Underdeveloped Africa*, chapter 1

Chapter 1 is called "Some Questions on Development." Rodney was a historian from Guyana. He wrote the book while teaching at the University of Dar es Salaam in Tanzania, and it came out in 1972.

1. What development means

Rodney starts with the word itself. For a person, development means growing in skill, freedom and well-being. For a society, it means people gaining more control over their lives and what they make together.

2. Underdevelopment is a comparison

Every people have developed in their own way. "Underdeveloped" only makes sense when you compare one country to another.

3. It came from a relationship

His big claim is that Africa's poverty and Europe's wealth are connected. One side was exploited and the other gained from it.

4. Poverty isn't natural

He pushes back on the idea that some places are just meant to be poor. That idea, he says, hides the history.

5. Some people at home benefit too

Rodney points out that a small group inside poor countries often gains from the arrangement, which helps keep it in place.

Read with this in mind

When people say a place is "behind," ask: behind by whose measure, and how did it get there?

A fair thing to argue about

Economists still argue about how much of today's gap comes from colonial history and how much from other causes. What do you think, and why?

Talk it through

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READING CIRCLE · WEEK 4

Johanna Fernández, *The Young Lords: A Radical History*

Published in 2020 by the University of North Carolina Press. Fernández is a historian. The Young Lords were young Puerto Ricans in New York who organized in East Harlem starting in 1969. Pick any one chapter.

1. They asked first

The group asked neighbors what they needed most. People said garbage, so in the summer of 1969 the Lords started sweeping streets and piling the trash the city wasn't picking up.

2. Meeting needs built trust

They ran breakfast for kids, clothing drives, and door-to-door testing for lead poisoning and tuberculosis.

3. They took over spaces

In December 1969 they occupied a church in East Harlem and ran programs from it. In July 1970 they took over Lincoln Hospital in the Bronx to protest poor care.

4. They had their own paper

Their newspaper, *Pa'lante*, spread news and ideas between neighborhoods.

5. Young people led

Most members were teenagers and people in their early twenties. Women in the group also pushed it to take sexism inside the group seriously.

Read with this in mind

Which of their programs could a small group of friends start today, at a much smaller scale?

A fair thing to argue about

Some of their tactics were confrontational. When is that the right call, and when does it push neighbors away?

Talk it through

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READING CIRCLE · WEEK 5

Gal Beckerman, *The Quiet Before*, the introduction

The full title is *The Quiet Before: On the Unexpected Origins of Radical Ideas* (Crown, 2022). Beckerman is a journalist and editor. He looks at how big movements grew out of small, slow conversations.

1. Ideas need a quiet place to grow

Before the big protest, there's usually a long stretch of people talking, writing and arguing in small groups.

2. Slow tools mattered

His examples include the Chartists in 1800s Britain, an underground workers' newsletter in 1970s Poland called *Robotnik*, and zines. These were slow to make and slow to read, and that gave people time to think together.

3. Social media is fast

He argues social media is great at getting people into the street quickly, and weaker at the slow thinking that keeps a movement going afterward.

Read with this in mind

Think about where you actually talk about big ideas with people you trust. Is it online, in person, or not at all?

Why this fits a reading circle

A reading circle is one of those quiet places. This week is a good time to talk about how your group is going so far.

A fair thing to argue about

Some movements did grow fast online and lasted. Is Beckerman too hard on social media?

Talk it through

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READING CIRCLE · WEEK 6

Thomas Sowell, *Intellectuals and Society*, one chapter

First published in 2009 by Basic Books. Sowell is an economist and a well-known conservative writer. This week is practice in hearing someone who sees things very differently from the rest of the list.

1. Who he means by intellectuals

Sowell means people whose work is ideas, like professors, writers and commentators. Their product is opinions and theories.

2. No cost for being wrong

An engineer whose bridge falls down pays a price. Sowell argues that intellectuals whose ideas fail often pay nothing, while regular people live with the results.

3. Knowledge is spread out

He argues that ordinary people hold a lot of practical knowledge about their own lives that experts don't have.

Read with this in mind

Where does he sound like a challenge to the other books on this list? Is there anything you agree with?

A connection to the circle

Some of his point fits with "ask your neighbors first," which is what the Young Lords did in week 4.

A fair thing to argue about

Does his criticism apply to people on every side of politics, including people he agrees with? Should it apply to us?

Talk it through

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